

Sanctity and freedom of the human being

A letter from Priest Seraphim. New Martyrs of the Turkish Yoke. 3rd Sunday after Pentecost.

June 20/July 3, 2022

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-07-03+martyrs-turkish-yoke+sanctity-freedom-way-of-death-or-life.docx

http://www.orthodox.net/letters/letter_2022-07-03+martyrs-turkish-yoke+sanctity-freedom-way-of-death-or-life.pdf

True Christians are not surprised by the hate of the world

The ongoing debate and the virulence of the words and ideas regarding the overturning of Roe versus Wade should not be surprising to a true Christian. By true Christian, I mean someone who lives according to their espoused Christianity. We are all sinners, but if we are not striving for perfection as we are called to strive, we are not true Christians. If we do not love our enemies (anyone who says he loves his enemies, or for that matter, his friends, and does not pray for them is a liar), then we are not true Christians.

The Remembrance of Death.

If we do not acquire and *be acquiring* the skill of “remembrance of death,” we are not true Christians. The remembrance of death can be defined as a Christian knowing that not only will he die but that everything he does is either life or death. This is a binary decision. Of course, sometimes we are faced with a difficult decision we don’t know the right path. In those decisions, In talking about decisions in which the soul tells us which way is life and which is death. We should learn to have the courage to make more binary decisions.

The skill of the remembrance of death is attained by constant immersion in the way of the Spirit. This is why I’m constantly talking about regular prayer, with prayer for others, reading the Psalter and doing our prostrations and the Jesus Prayer, and coming to the services and reading the Holy Scriptures. And we are continually forcing ourselves to do good and act according to the urgings of our hearts. This is the root of Christian asceticism.

We will naturally do the things *most* that we value the *most*. If we value our faith and love God in any way that approaches the fulfillment of the great commandment, we will immerse ourselves in Christian things. What are Christian “things”? They are everything! There is nothing exempt from our professed faith. Everything must be done by the way of the Spirit. There is nothing secular. Everything is spiritual. I tell everyone who will listen, and probably some who don’t, about this because I do it myself. I do it poorly, just as most of us do it poorly, but I value the way of the Spirit and long to live fully in this way.

The way of death and the way of life.

The world is constantly immersed in the way of the flesh. Even the words Christians use are used by those in the world in a way that is according to the flesh. Unfortunately, lamentably, even some of those who call themselves Orthodox Christians are extremely upset because Roe versus Wade was overturned. They use some of the standard arguments of the pro-abortion lobby, not understanding that there is a way of life and a way of death. They don’t understand that it is *never right to do the wrong thing*. It is certainly not right to

legislate the demonic sacrifice of our children to Moloch because of a small percentage of things in which the sacrifice *appears* to be helpful to the mother, such as when a woman is pregnant by incest or rape. This is only the appearance of good. *It is never right to do the wrong thing.* If a woman has been abused physically or emotionally, the effects of that abuse do not decrease if she becomes an abuser. No matter what we have done, there is repentance. We should always remember that for ourselves and anyone else.

Unfortunately, lamentably, our society values death above life. They would rather the woman kill that which is within her because it is life. The killing of that which is life within her increases the insanity and the chaos of society, and has a ripple effect that causes many to be completely confused about what it means to be a human being. The vast majority of individuals would protest vehemently that they do not prefer death over life, but those who do not know their purpose and/or are influenced by the tossing and turning of popular opinion and coercion are blank canvases for the Evil One and the spiritual wickedness in high places. The demons prefer the death of the body and the soul over life. Because of the abortion lobby, adoption is expensive and complicated. Many times, a woman does not feel like she has any options. This is because society values the death of her baby more than life.

Christians in the world use some of the same words differently, such as “sanctity,” “love” and “freedom.”

The world doesn’t understand these things because they are accustomed to listening to the talking points they hear and watch so often on their phones. We are not the world. We are Christians.

I recently read the words of a person arguing that we should support the “*sanctity*” of a woman’s body. Of course, this is true. The Christian despises all slavery, abuse, and coercion of any human being, whether a woman or child, or even a criminal. We understand that everyone is made in the image of God in order to obtain His likeness, and this is what gives *sanctity* to the human body and the whole human being, body and soul. This is not a *sanctity* enshrined by human law but by God’s law. Therefore, when the word “*sanctity*” is used to give a woman the supposed “right” to kill the baby that is within her womb, the word is being used in a way that is demonic and ungodly. The child within her womb also has “*sanctity*” because that child is also made in the image of God in order to obtain His likeness. Even modern biology understands that the unborn child is not part of the mother’s body, and our theology understands that this child’s soul is also distinct from that of its mother. In every way that matters, the child is equal to its mother.

There are many other words that the world uses in an ungodly way. The world says “*love is love,*” forgetting or ignoring that love without truth is not love. And truth without love is not love or truth.

The world also speaks of *personal freedom*, such as the freedom of a woman to abort her child, or the freedom of someone to choose which gender they identify as, which sexual preference(s) they have, or whichever lifestyle they wish to choose for themselves. The world does not understand that the word “freedom” only means “freedom” when the soul is free, and the soul is only free when it is free from sin. The Scripture tells us plainly that he who sins becomes a slave of sin. Therefore, the very things the world says are “freedom” are actually slavery.

A Christian understands the only path to true freedom is slavery. The world thinks of slavery as something odious and terrible, and as it is practiced in the world, it is. For a Christian, slavery to the One who knows all things and can do all things and loves us perfectly is the only way to be perfectly free. The Christian

understands that he is not perfectly free because he is encumbered by the chains of sin. He despises these chains, and he struggles against them, somewhat like a child who tried to lift a heavy weight. What is quite impossible for a child to do, God will do, if we are struggling for virtue.

I wanted to write much more for you this week. I wanted to include some things about St. John Maximovitch whom we commemorated on Saturday. I'm finishing this letter on Saturday evening after the vigil (well, actually on Monday morning. Time flies!). This Sunday is one of my favorite feasts because I love the New martyrs of the Turkish Yoke. I pray to dozens of them, and the vast majority are those that apostatized and then, as the Scripture says regarding the prodigal son: "came to themselves" and usually in obedience to an elder, prepared for martyrdom and then sought it and were rewarded with paradise. Unfortunately, there are only so many hours in a day and too many other things to do. So, I must be satisfied with not allowing my idea of a perfect letter to get in the way of writing one that I hope is "good enough." May God help us all to find paradise.

In Christ, unworthy Priest Seraphim.

This personal letter is an attempt to keep in touch. I don't know how to stay in touch in many circumstances because sometimes we haven't seen each other for a long time or see each other irregularly, but I do know how to write. It has become impossible for me to lay eyes on or greet everyone who comes to church on Sunday. If you reply to me, I'll do my best to write you soon as possible.

Recent stuff:

[A Christian reaction to the Supreme Court overturning of Row v Wade](#) Audio or Video

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/misc_2022+christian-reaction-to-roe-v-wade-overturn.mp3

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/W4CsJBG9W4k>

On the day after the historic overturning of Roe V Wade by the Supreme Court, we talk about the sober reaction a Christian must have to this news. It is never right to do something that is wrong. Overturning an immoral law is necessary, but NOT SUFFICIENT. We should not "celebrate" – we must increase our prayer. There is still a terrible amount of suffering.

Apologies about the recording quality. I made a mistake in recording. If I have time, I will edit the transcript and record again. This is a critical topic, and I did not want to let perfection be the enemy of the good (enough).

[Confession talk at St Iakovos camp: what, why, how?](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/catechism/catechism_2022-06-23+confession-talk-at-st-iakovos-camp.mp3

Talk to youth at St Iakovos camp about confession, with Fr Seraphim and Sister Maxime. **WHAT** is it for, and what does the priest think of someone who confesses a terrible sin, and, **WHY** do we confess, **HOW** to prepare for it. And other stuff, such as what is the one thing in your life you cannot do without and why should we pray for anyone who harms us. IT is a lot, in about 25 minutes.

0:09 – 8:16 What is confession for?

8:25 – 11:29 Why pray for those who have harmed you, and how to pray for them.

11:29 – 13:42 What to confess? Not a list of "things"; it is not "formal". And about modern forms of confession that are not beneficial.

13:42 – 18:27 How do you prepare for confession? Concentrate on who you are, and your relationships.

18:35 – 22:03 What is one thing in your life you cannot do without?

22:05 – 25:15 What does the priest think about someone if they confess a terrible sin? Will his opinion of the person be negative

23:45 - 24:48 Sins of the flesh

[The message of Pentecost: "I will give you an heart of flesh ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God."](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+a-heart-of-flesh+ye-shall-be-my-people-and-i-will-be-your-god.mp3

A quick exegesis of the three Vespers Old Testament readings for Pentecost, with much lingering on the last, from Ezekiel 36:24-28. Herein is the message (result) of Pentecost: "A new heart also will I give you, and a new spirit will I put within you: and I will take away the stony heart out of your flesh, and I will give you an heart of flesh. ...and ye shall be my people, and I will be your God."

8:41 the cure for a stony heart.

9:26 You must know that you can be a very bad person ... in order to become good. And 14:03 – 14:49

10:13 Ezekiel

[Pentecost: The appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope.](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pentecost_2022+the-appointed-day-of-promise-and-the-fulfillment-of-hope.mp3

4:29 Commentary on the first hymn sung about Pentecost in the vigil: "We celebrate Pentecost, * and the descent of the Spirit, * and the appointed day of promise, and the fulfillment of hope. * And such a mystery! Both great and venerable! * Wherefore, we cry out unto Thee: * O Lord, Maker of all things, glory to Thee! " and a reflection on *what* the promise of Pentecost is, a promise unlike any other religion in the world. By Priest Nicholas Park

["In a little while ... your heart shall rejoice, and your joy no man taketh from you." Can we wait?](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-wed-07_2022+in-a-little-while_john16-15-23.mp3

2022-06-08 13 minutes. Exegesis of John 16:15-23, especially noting the apparent and spiritual meaning of: "a little while." Anything that is repeated in Scripture is important in this phrase is repeated five times. We also talk about the joy of the world which is as a psychotic laughing, and our joy, if we are can wait "a little while". We also talk about what we know of the next life. The Lord tells us that our sorrow will be turned into joy. He compares this joy to a woman who was given birth. If we understand even a little bit about this joy we will be able to wait "a little while."

Video: [New Martyr Alexander of Thessalonica +06-26-1794](#)

The New Martyr Alexander lived many years in deep apostasy before coming to his senses and being washed in the blood of martyrdom. His last hour alive on earth was very unique!

YouTube: <https://youtu.be/uo6PK0SDBdY>

[Christians live with the certainty that the future is in the present. High priestly prayer of Jesus Christ.](#)

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+holy-fathers+live-as-if-the-future-is-the-present_john17-1-13.mp3

Exegesis, with application to our lives, of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ from John 17:1 through 13. We ask first why do we commemorate the fathers of the First Ecumenical Council and read this prayer on the Sunday before Pentecost? Then we go into all of the proofs that Jesus Christ is God and is completely equal to the Father, using the words of His prayer. And all of this must be applied! There are two applications. The first is that we must live in such a way that we are one with God since this is Jesus' prayer for us. We must understand what this means in order to live in this way. Our Lord also stated that He had completed the work that His Father had given him to do, even before He Jesus had been arrested and tried and crucified and all the rest. In chronological terms He had not completed the work but Christians live according to the future in the present. We talk about this at length. This is the only way to live especially in our troubled times when there will be many troubles coming. If we live only according to the present we will be lost if we live according to the future in our present, we will be saved. About 18min 2022-06-05

Partial (Audio) Timestamps.

0:17 – 1:28 Why commemorate the Fathers of the First Ecumenical council and read the high priestly prayer of Jesus Christ on the Sunday between Ascension and Pentecost?

1:28 – 7:27 All the parts of the High Priestly prayer of Jesus Christ which prove that He is God

3:53 – 4:17 "And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent" John 17:3

4:17 - 5:49 "And now, O Father, glorify thou me with thine own self with the glory which I had with thee before the world was" (John 15:5)

5:49 - 6:28 "Now they have known that all things whatsoever thou hast given me are of thee. 8 For I have given unto them the words which thou gavest me; and they have received them, and have known surely that I came out from thee, and they have believed that thou didst send me" (John 17:7-8)

6:28 – 6:46 "And all mine are thine, and thine are mine; and I am glorified in them." (John 17:10)

6:46 – 7:27 "Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are" (John 17:11)

1:52 - 2:53 Why do we Orthodox stress so much the dogma that Jesus Christ is God and Man/ Why did 1000's of saints die to protect this dogma? What is the big deal?

5:01 – 5:41 We do not believe in "nice Jesus", as much of the so-called Christian world believes.

7:27 – 10:06 The APPLICATION of the dogma that Jesus Christ is one with the Father, and His prayer: "Holy Father, keep through thine own name those whom thou hast given me, that they may be one, as we are." And "these things I speak in the world, that they might have my joy fulfilled in themselves."

10:06 – end APPLICATION of Jesus' prayer: "4 I have glorified thee on the earth: I have finished the work which thou gavest me to do" (John 17:4)

Fathers of First Council. "Who hath rent thy garment?"

http://www.orthodox.net/sermons/pascha-sun-07_2022+fathers-of-first-council+who-hath-rent-thy-garment.mp3

Fr Nicholas gives an exegesis of one of the hymns from Vespers in honor of the Holy Fathers of the First Ecumenical Council: "O My Savior, who hath thus rent Thy raiment? / Thou didst say: It was Arius / who sundered the Trinity's headship, / which is one in rank and honor. / That Thou art One of the Most Holy Trinity he disputed: / and he taught Nestorius the godless not to say Theotokos. / But the Council gathered in Nicaea / proclaimed that Thou, O Lord, art truly the Son of God, // one with the Father and the Spirit in rank." About 5 min. 2022-06-04